MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 4: Periodical Essays

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

The periodical essay creates an ongoing conversation in which selected voices discuss conduct, manners, social observation, and moral self-examination.

Start with a picture

A familiar writer returns regularly with a short piece. Readers begin to recognise the voice, revisit characters, and compare the day’s reflection with their own behaviour. Repetition creates a relationship beyond any one essay.

1. The Tatler and The Spectator

Steele founded The Tatler in 1709, with Addison contributing. The Spectator followed in 1711 through their collaboration. Regular publication, a persona, and observations of everyday conduct helped create a style of sociable instruction.

Do not infer that the form existed only between two exact dates. Its strongest association with the early eighteenth century does not mean later short periodical prose ceased to exist.

2. A fictional public

The Spectator Club provides continuity through characters such as Sir Roger, Freeport, and Honeycomb. Their differences let the essay suggest conversation across occupations and habits.

The social range is selected. The apparently general voice of polite society can leave many people outside its assumed membership.

3. Character, humour, and improvement

An anecdote or portrait can make an ethical observation easier to encounter than a formal lecture. Affectionate irony permits pleasure and criticism to coexist. The reader is invited to recognise a habit without necessarily being directly accused.

Analyse how a detail works: a household custom may reveal kindness, hierarchy, eccentricity, or more than one of these at once.

4. Johnson’s periodical voice

The Rambler develops sustained moral and psychological reflection. Its heavier style and reception differ from the ideal of effortless sociability. Initial commercial response and later literary value are different questions; do not assume a single explanation settles both.

On Procrastination exemplifies the examination of intention, excuse, and the use of limited time.

5. Goldsmith and variety

Goldsmith’s lighter, humane observation and fictional perspectives offer another mode of social criticism. The essay can approach an established custom from an unfamiliar viewpoint and reveal its strangeness.

6. How to study the form

Connect publication rhythm, persona, anecdote, style, audience, and moral purpose. A short piece can be formally complex. The periodical essay also shares techniques with character writing and the developing novel without becoming identical to either.

Quick check

1. Is Addison the sole founder of The Tatler? **No; Steele founded it.**
2. Does a polite narrator speak for everybody? **No.**
3. Is the essay only a container for a moral? **No; persona and method shape its effect.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain recurring publication and familiarity.
2. Discuss persona and club continuity.
3. Analyse humour and sociable instruction.
4. Contrast Johnson and Goldsmith.
5. Evaluate whose conduct and readership define the public.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not accept the claim that periodical essays existed for only one fixed fifty-year span or confuse a publication’s reception with one universal reader response.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Explain the relationship between periodical publication, persona, and moral instruction.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The periodical essay depends on repetition as an institution and as a reading experience. A returning voice creates familiarity, while separate pieces address varied aspects of conduct. The form can consequently offer continuity without the sustained plot of a novel or the systematic organisation of a treatise.

Addison and Steele use sociability to make moral reflection agreeable. A character sketch or apparently casual observation gives a judgement a lived setting. The Spectator Club widens the fictional conversation, but its selection also reveals the limits of the public being imagined. A confident communal voice should therefore remain an object of analysis.

Johnson demonstrates that the same broad medium can support a different tone. The Rambler's sustained reasoning turns attention towards self-deception and difficult habits. Goldsmith's perspectives introduce further variety. Historical reception cannot be explained by assuming that every reader preferred one style or that initial sales settled literary importance.

A strong account connects these differences with particular techniques. Publication, speaker, example, and audience work together to produce the educational effect. The essay does not merely announce a moral; it creates a relationship in which the reader is encouraged to consider it.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Addisons' contributions to The Tatler.
2. How was the character of Sir Roger de Coverley caricatured?
3. What was the fascinating aspect of The Spectator?
4. What is the reason behind the initial failure of The Rambler ?
5. What was the speciality of Oliver Goldsmith's writing compared to that of Johnson?